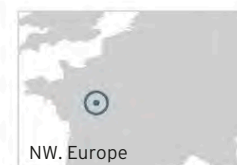


Château de Chenonceau

The loveliest of the châteaux on the Loire and, after Versailles, the most visited of all French castles



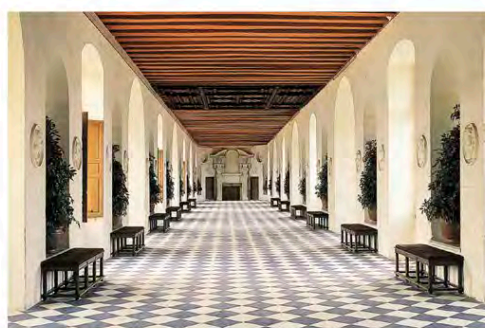
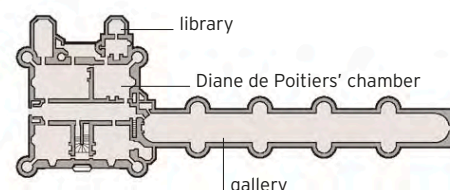
Standing slightly apart from the main body of the château, a 15th-century circular tower is the only surviving remnant of a fortified manor house, which in 1513 passed to Thomas Bohier, a royal chamberlain. His wife, Katherine Briçonnet, rebuilt the manor into the château seen today.

The Ladies' Castle

Chenonceau is known as the Ladies' Castle because women played a major role in its construction and preservation. Diane de Poitiers (1500–1566), the mistress of Henri II, had the greatest impact. In the 1550s, she commissioned architect Philibert de l'Orme to build the fine, arched bridge and long gallery spanning the Cher River; she also oversaw the creation of the magnificent gardens. Queen Catherine de' Medici, Henri's widow, later forced Diane to exchange Chenonceau for another château, and under her the upper floor of the gallery was added by architect Jean Bullant in 1576–1578. Mary, Queen of Scots, stayed at the château briefly, but the most tragic inhabitant was Louise de Lorraine. After the assassination of her husband, Henri III, she became a recluse here, surrounding herself with somber tapestries decorated with skulls, crosses, and burial shovels. The château is currently owned by the Meniers, a famous family of chocolatiers.

CHAMBERS OF THE RIVAL LADIES

The two great rivals favored the same living area in the château. Diane de Poitiers' chamber is on the ground floor and Catherine de' Medici's bedroom is directly above it. The latter is currently furnished with early Flemish tapestries and an ornate four-poster bed.



◀ GRAND GALLERY

Chenonceau's stunning gallery is 197 ft (60 m) long. With its elegant chalk-and-slate tiled floor, it served as a ballroom in its heyday.

▽ RIVAL GARDENS

Diane de Poitiers' garden, shown here, was planted on the right side of the castle, while Catherine de' Medici created hers on the left.

